

Slope and Mesic Forest

PHOTO BY ALAN CRESSLER

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Slope and mesic forests in Georgia, often found on cooler, moist north or east-facing slopes, have historically supported high-value hardwoods like tulip poplar, northern red oak, and basswood.

Due to steep terrain and limited access, many of these forests were less intensively logged, allowing some stands to mature, especially in remote areas. However, where accessible, they were selectively harvested for furniture-grade timber and veneer logs.

Past operations sometimes led to erosion and soil instability, especially where roads or skid trails were poorly sited.

Today, these forests are managed for both ecological value and economic timber, with operations guided by BMPs to protect water quality, prevent slope failure, and support wildlife habitat in these sensitive landscapes.



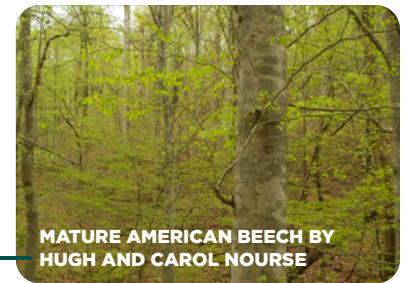
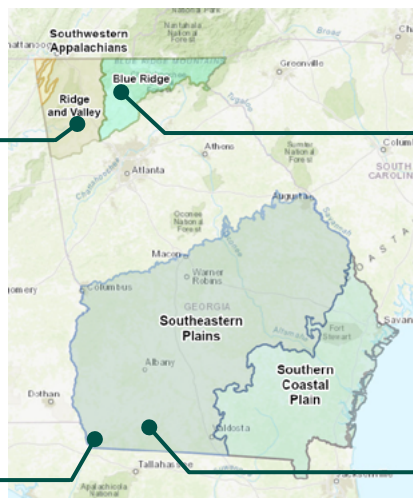
EARLY HAIRSTREAK
(*ERORA LAETA*) BY JAMES K. ADAMS

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Mesic forests are cool, shaded sites such as north and east-facing slopes within ravines and on terraces by streams. Soils in these habitats are moist but not saturated. Typical trees include American beech, white oak, northern red oak, bitternut hickory, pignut hickory, shagbark hickory, bigleaf magnolia, yellow poplar, blackgum, dogwood, black cherry, and loblolly pine. Typical shrubs include spicebush, sweetshrub, pawpaw, Oconee azalea, rusty viburnum, and pinxter bloom azalea.



**MESIC HARDWOOD FOREST
RAVINETRILLIUM MARKED
TIMBER BY GA DNR**



**MATURE AMERICAN BEECH BY
HUGH AND CAROL NOURSE**



**STEEPHEAD ALUM BLUFF
BY ALAN CRESSLER**



**BEECH MAGNOLIA CLIMAX
FOREST BY TALL TIMBERS
RESEARCH STATION**

SWAP Priority Habitat	Ecoregion(s)
Beech-Magnolia Slope Forests	Southeastern Plains/ Southern Coastal Plain
Hemlock-Hardwood-White Pine Forests	Blue Ridge
Forested Limestone Slopes and Terraces	Southwestern Appalachians/ Ridge & Valley
Mesic Hardwood Forests	
Limestone and Marl Outcrops; Calcareous Bluffs	Southeastern Plains
Steephead Ravines	

THREATS

- **Habitat loss, degradation, and fragmentation, including clearing and conversion of habitat to agriculture, and residential and commercial development**
- **Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals**

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- **Retire fire breaks and allow fires to burn through these areas when possible.**
- **Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.**
- **Clean vehicles, tractors, and equipment between sites if invasive species are present. If operations cannot be avoided in areas where invasive species are present, conduct operations in these areas last.**
- **Maintain open canopy through selective thinning, if needed.**
- **Avoid offroad vehicle use. When roads or firebreaks are necessary, use Georgia's BMP manual to construct water bars, broad based dips, stream crossings and other practices to reduce erosion and runoff.**

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard for more information and resources

